EMPLOYEE HANDBOOK

A fictional, synthetic handbook for RAG pipeline testing

Organization	Northstar Example Labs, Inc.
Version	1.0 — Sample
Effective date	January 1, 2026 (fictional)
Document owner	People Operations (fictional)
Intended use	Personal experimentation, document parsing, chunking, retrieval, and evaluation

IMPORTANT: This document is entirely fictional and is not legal, HR, tax, or employment advice. It is not a real company's policy and should not be used as an operational handbook.

Synthetic content includes sample rules, dates, names, benefits, procedures, and contact details. All people, departments, and contact addresses are invented.

Contents

This sample uses distinct headings, policy identifiers, dates, and repeated terminology to support retrieval testing.

1. About This Handbook
2. Employment Basics
3. Working Hours and Attendance
4. Remote and Hybrid Work
5. Leave and Time Off
6. Compensation and Payroll
7. Benefits and Learning
8. Standards of Conduct
9. Anti-Harassment and Reporting
10. Information Security and Privacy
11. Devices, Software, and AI Tools
12. Workplace Safety and Emergencies
13. Performance and Development
14. Travel and Expense Reimbursement
15. Separation of Employment
16. Frequently Asked Questions

Appendix A. Sample Contacts

Appendix B. Retrieval Test Facts

1. About This Handbook

Northstar Example Labs, Inc. is a fictional company that builds internal workflow software for small organizations. This handbook describes illustrative workplace practices for a made-up company.

1.1 Purpose and scope

The handbook is a reference guide for hypothetical employees, managers, and contractors. It summarizes example expectations and procedures. If two sections appear inconsistent, use the more specific section for the sample scenario and record the inconsistency during evaluation.

1.2 Policy identifiers

Each policy has an identifier such as HR-101 or IT-204. These identifiers are synthetic and exist to make retrieval and citation tests easier. A policy identifier is not a legal reference.

1.3 Updates

The fictional People Operations team reviews the handbook every six months. The sample review dates are April 1 and October 1. Changes are recorded in a revision log with the policy ID, revision date, and a one-sentence summary.

1.4 Questions

Employees in this fictional setting can contact People Operations at people-ops@example.invalid. The .invalid domain is reserved for examples and is not a working company email.

2. Employment Basics

HR-101 — Equal opportunity

Northstar Example Labs aims to provide a respectful workplace and fair access to employment opportunities. Decisions about hiring, assignments, development, and promotion should be based on role-related criteria, business needs, and documented performance. This fictional statement is illustrative and does not replace applicable law.

HR-102 — Employment categories

Sample worker categories are regular full-time, regular part-time, fixed-term, and independent contractor. The offer letter or services agreement identifies the category, expected schedule, compensation terms, and manager. Contractors are not automatically eligible for employee benefits in this fictional policy.

HR-103 — Introductory period

New regular employees have a 60-calendar-day introductory period. The manager schedules check-ins around days 15, 30, and 55. Completing the period does not guarantee continued employment or a particular rating.

HR-104 — Personnel records

Employees should notify People Operations of changes to their mailing address, emergency contact, legal name, or payroll details through the fictional employee portal. Access to personnel records is limited to authorized staff with a business need.

3. Working Hours and Attendance

OPS-110 — Standard schedule

The sample standard schedule is Monday through Friday, 9:00 a.m. to 5:30 p.m. local office time, including a 30-minute unpaid meal break. Team coverage may vary. A manager must communicate schedule changes in advance when practical.

OPS-111 — Flexible hours

Employees may request a flexible start between 8:00 a.m. and 10:00 a.m. The request should specify the proposed start time, end time, collaboration hours, and expected duration. The manager responds within five business days.

OPS-112 — Attendance and lateness

If an employee expects to be more than 10 minutes late, they should notify their manager in the team channel or by phone before the scheduled start when feasible. Repeated attendance concerns are discussed privately and documented consistently.

OPS-113 — Overtime approval

For this synthetic example, non-exempt employees should obtain written manager approval before planned overtime. Hours actually worked must still be recorded accurately. This sample rule is not a statement of legal requirements in any jurisdiction.

4. Remote and Hybrid Work

WORK-120 — Hybrid schedule

The default fictional hybrid schedule is three remote days and two office days per week. Teams select office days at the start of each quarter. New hires may be asked to attend more in-person sessions during onboarding.

WORK-121 — Remote-work requests

Employees requesting fully remote work submit a short plan covering location, time zone, equipment, data privacy, and team availability. The manager and People Operations review the plan within ten business days. Approval may be time-limited and reviewed quarterly.

WORK-122 — Home workspace

Employees should use a stable work surface, protect screens from public view, and take reasonable breaks. Company information should not be discussed where unauthorized people can overhear it. Report equipment or accessibility needs to the manager.

WORK-123 — Working across time zones

Core collaboration hours are 11:00 a.m. to 2:00 p.m. in the team's agreed reference time zone. Meetings outside an employee's normal working hours should be minimized and rotated where practical.

5. Leave and Time Off

LEAVE-130 — Annual leave

The fictional full-time employee allowance is 20 working days per calendar year, prorated for eligible start dates. Employees request leave in the HR portal. Managers aim to respond within three business days. Approval depends on coverage and previously approved absences.

LEAVE-131 — Sick time

The sample policy provides 8 paid sick days per calendar year. Employees should notify their manager as soon as practical when illness affects work. A manager should not request unnecessary diagnostic details in routine absence messages.

LEAVE-132 — Public holidays

The sample company observes 10 public holidays per year. The People Operations team publishes the annual calendar by December 1 of the preceding year. Holiday dates may differ by employee location in a real organization.

LEAVE-133 — Parental and caregiving leave

Employees may contact People Operations to discuss parental, adoption, or caregiving leave options. The sample handbook intentionally does not define a universal duration; the fictional benefits guide and individual circumstances determine the example plan.

LEAVE-134 — Carryover

Up to 5 unused annual-leave days may be carried into the next calendar year in this fictional policy. Carried days must be used by March 31. Sick days do not carry over in this sample.

LEAVE-135 — Leave example

If an eligible employee begins the year with 20 annual-leave days and uses 12, the remaining balance is 8 days. If the employee carries 5 days into the next year, those 5 carried days expire after March 31 unless a written exception is approved.

6. Compensation and Payroll

PAY-140 — Pay cycle

The fictional payroll cycle is biweekly, with payment every other Friday. If a scheduled payment date falls on a bank holiday, the sample payroll team aims to process payment on the preceding business day.

PAY-141 — Payroll corrections

Employees who notice a possible pay discrepancy should submit a ticket to payroll@example.invalid with the pay date, a description of the discrepancy, and supporting records. The sample service target is an initial response within three business days.

PAY-142 — Salary confidentiality

Employees may discuss their own compensation as permitted by applicable law and policy. Managers should handle compensation information carefully and share another person's details only with authorized recipients for a legitimate business reason.

PAY-143 — Deductions and taxes

Actual deductions and tax treatment depend on the employee's circumstances and applicable rules. This synthetic handbook does not calculate tax, define statutory deductions, or promise a net-pay amount.

7. Benefits and Learning

BEN-150 — Health and wellbeing allowance

The fictional company offers a wellbeing reimbursement of up to 600 currency units per calendar year. Eligible examples include fitness classes, ergonomic accessories, and mindfulness courses. Alcohol, gifts, and personal entertainment are excluded.

BEN-151 — Learning budget

Eligible employees may request up to 1,200 currency units per year for role-related courses, books, or conferences. Requests must explain the learning objective, estimated cost, and connection to current responsibilities. Manager approval is required before purchase.

BEN-152 — Equipment stipend

New employees may request a one-time home-office stipend of up to 400 currency units within their first 90 days. Receipts and a short business-purpose note are required. The stipend cannot be exchanged for cash.

BEN-153 — Benefit questions

Questions about eligibility, reimbursement timing, or supporting documents should be sent to benefits@example.invalid. The sample response target is five business days.

8. Standards of Conduct

CON-160 — Professional behavior

Employees should communicate respectfully, give feedback about work rather than personal characteristics, and avoid threats, intimidation, or deliberate disruption. Disagreements should be raised directly when safe and appropriate, or through the reporting channels in Section 9.

CON-161 — Conflicts of interest

Employees should disclose outside work, financial interests, gifts, or close personal relationships that could reasonably affect business decisions. Disclosure does not automatically mean a conflict exists. The manager and People Operations agree on proportionate safeguards.

CON-162 — Gifts and hospitality

The sample threshold for a non-cash business gift is 75 currency units. Gifts above that value must be declined or disclosed for review. Cash and cash-equivalent gifts should not be accepted. Local laws and customer rules may be stricter.

CON-163 — Company property

Company equipment and accounts are provided for authorized work. Limited personal use may be allowed if it is lawful, secure, and does not interfere with work. Employees must return company property at the end of employment.

CON-164 — Social media

Employees should not disclose confidential information or imply that personal opinions represent the company. Only authorized spokespeople may issue official statements on behalf of Northstar Example Labs.

9. Anti-Harassment and Reporting

SAFE-170 — Respectful workplace

Harassment, discrimination, retaliation, and bullying are not accepted in this fictional workplace. Reports are assessed promptly and as impartially as practical. Confidentiality is limited to people who need information to respond fairly and safely.

SAFE-171 — Reporting channels

Employees may report a concern to their manager, People Operations, or the independent sample contact at speakup@example.invalid. If the manager is involved in the concern, employees may bypass that manager and contact People Operations directly.

SAFE-172 — What to include

A report may include dates, locations, people involved, witnesses, relevant messages, and the outcome the reporter is seeking. A report does not need to contain every detail to be considered. Do not investigate or confront someone if doing so could create a safety risk.

SAFE-173 — Non-retaliation

Retaliation against a person for raising a good-faith concern or participating in a review is prohibited by this sample policy. Anyone who believes retaliation occurred should report it through one of the channels in SAFE-171.

SAFE-174 — Response process

The fictional response process is: acknowledge the report within two business days, assess immediate safety needs, select an appropriate reviewer, gather relevant information, document findings, and communicate the outcome to the extent appropriate. Complex cases may take longer.

10. Information Security and Privacy

SEC-180 — Data classification

The sample data classes are Public, Internal, Confidential, and Restricted. Public information is approved for open release. Internal information is for ordinary business use. Confidential information includes non-public plans and customer details. Restricted information includes credentials, sensitive personal data, and security secrets.

SEC-181 — Passwords and multifactor authentication

Use a unique password for each work account and enable multifactor authentication wherever available. Do not share passwords or one-time codes with colleagues or support personnel. Store credentials only in the approved password manager.

SEC-182 — Phishing

Treat unexpected attachments, urgent payment requests, login links, and requests for credentials with caution. Verify unusual requests using a separate known channel. Forward suspected phishing messages to security@example.invalid and do not click suspicious links.

SEC-183 — Incident reporting

Report a lost device, misdirected email, suspected account compromise, or accidental disclosure to security@example.invalid as soon as possible. Include what happened, when it happened, the systems or data involved, and any containment steps already taken.

SEC-184 — Retention and deletion

Keep business records in approved systems and follow the retention schedule set by the relevant team. Do not destroy records subject to a formal preservation request. Personal copies of confidential files should not be stored on unmanaged devices.

SEC-185 — Privacy principle

Collect only the personal information needed for a stated business purpose, restrict access, and use approved systems to transfer it. Employees should raise questions about unfamiliar data requests before sharing information.

11. Devices, Software, and AI Tools

IT-190 — Approved software

Install software only from the approved company catalog or after IT approval. Do not disable endpoint protection or bypass device management. Requests for new software should state the business need, data accessed, and whether an external account is required.

IT-191 — Generative AI tools

Use only AI tools approved for the relevant data classification. Do not paste Restricted information, credentials, unreleased customer data, or confidential personnel records into public AI services. Review AI-generated output for accuracy, bias, privacy, and intellectual-property concerns before relying on it.

IT-192 — Human review

AI may assist with drafting, summarization, and brainstorming, but an accountable employee must review consequential outputs. Do not use an AI system as the sole decision-maker for hiring, performance ratings, compensation, discipline, or termination in this sample policy.

IT-193 — Source attribution

When AI-generated content incorporates material from external sources, verify the source and follow applicable attribution and licensing requirements. Do not represent fabricated citations, data, or quotations as verified facts.

IT-194 — Device loss

If a laptop or phone is lost, contact IT and Security immediately using a known contact method. Do not wait to see whether the device turns up. IT may revoke sessions, disable access, or remotely wipe managed company data.

12. Workplace Safety and Emergencies

SAFE-200 — General safety

Keep walkways clear, report damaged equipment, and follow posted building procedures. Do not attempt repairs that require training or authorization. Report hazards to the office coordinator or manager.

SAFE-201 — Emergency response

In an immediate emergency, contact local emergency services first and follow instructions from trained responders. Then notify the designated workplace contact when safe. This fictional handbook does not replace local emergency plans.

SAFE-202 — Evacuation

Know the nearest safe exit and assembly point for your work location. Do not use elevators during a fire evacuation unless emergency responders direct otherwise. Managers should not delay evacuation to collect equipment.

SAFE-203 — Ergonomics

Adjust chair, screen, and keyboard to a comfortable position. Take short movement breaks during long periods of screen work. Report persistent equipment or accessibility issues to the manager so suitable adjustments can be considered.

13. Performance and Development

PERF-210 — Check-ins

Managers hold monthly one-to-one conversations covering priorities, workload, feedback, and development. Employees may request an additional check-in when priorities change materially.

PERF-211 — Formal review cycle

The sample formal review cycle occurs in June and December. Employees submit a self-reflection, managers document outcomes against agreed goals, and a calibration discussion checks for consistency. Ratings should be supported by specific examples.

PERF-212 — Goal setting

Each employee should maintain three to five active goals. A useful goal identifies the outcome, measure of success, owner, and target date. Goals may be revised when business priorities change.

PERF-213 — Improvement support

When performance falls below expectations, the manager should explain the gap, provide concrete examples, agree on support, and set a review date. Any formal improvement plan should state expectations, resources, milestones, and the process for follow-up.

14. Travel and Expense Reimbursement

EXP-220 — Pre-approval

Business travel requires manager approval before booking. The request should include the business purpose, destination, dates, estimated cost, and relevant project or team.

EXP-221 — Expense submission

Submit expenses within 15 calendar days after the trip or purchase. Include an itemized receipt, date, amount, currency, business purpose, and attendee names when relevant. If a receipt is unavailable, explain why and provide alternative evidence.

EXP-222 — Reimbursement timeline

The sample finance team reviews complete claims within seven business days and aims to pay approved claims in the next payroll cycle. Incomplete claims may be returned for clarification.

EXP-223 — Non-reimbursable items

Examples of non-reimbursable items include personal entertainment, traffic fines, unapproved upgrades, expenses for family members, and duplicate claims. Exceptions require written approval and must comply with applicable rules.

15. Separation of Employment

EXIT-230 — Resignation notice

Employees should submit a written resignation to their manager and People Operations, stating the intended final working day. The applicable agreement and local requirements determine the notice period; this sample handbook does not set a universal legal notice period.

EXIT-231 — Handover

Before departure, employees should document current projects, open decisions, key contacts, recurring tasks, and file locations. Managers assign a recipient for each active responsibility.

EXIT-232 — Return of property

Return laptops, access cards, keys, storage devices, and other company property by the agreed final day. IT removes access according to the offboarding checklist. Employees should not keep unauthorized copies of company or customer data.

EXIT-233 — Final pay and records

People Operations and Payroll provide information about final pay, benefits, and employment records under the applicable process. Timing and entitlements depend on the employee's agreement and governing requirements.

16. Frequently Asked Questions

Q: How many annual-leave days are provided?

A: The fictional full-time allowance is 20 working days per calendar year, prorated when applicable (LEAVE-130).

Q: When is payroll paid?

A: Every other Friday under the sample biweekly payroll cycle (PAY-140).

Q: What is the learning budget?

A: Up to 1,200 currency units per year for eligible role-related learning, with manager approval before purchase (BEN-151).

Q: How quickly should a manager respond to a flexible-hours request?

A: Within five business days under OPS-111.

Q: What should I do after a suspected phishing email?

A: Avoid clicking suspicious links, verify unusual requests separately, and report the message to security@example.invalid (SEC-182).

Q: Can I paste confidential employee data into a public AI tool?

A: No. IT-191 prohibits putting Restricted information and confidential personnel records into public AI services.

Q: How soon should I submit an expense claim?

A: Within 15 calendar days after the trip or purchase (EXP-221).

Q: What is the hybrid schedule?

A: Three remote days and two office days per week by default, with office days selected quarterly (WORK-120).

Q: How many sick days are included?

A: The synthetic policy provides 8 paid sick days per calendar year (LEAVE-131).

Q: Where can I report retaliation?

A: Report it to a manager, People Operations, or speakup@example.invalid under SAFE-171 and SAFE-173.

Appendix A. Sample Contacts

Function	Sample contact	Use for
People Operations	people-ops@example.invalid	Personnel records, policy questions
Payroll	payroll@example.invalid	Pay discrepancies and payroll tickets
Benefits	benefits@example.invalid	Learning and wellbeing reimbursements
IT and Security	security@example.invalid	Phishing, incidents, lost devices
Speak-up channel	speakup@example.invalid	Workplace concerns and retaliation

All addresses use the reserved .invalid domain and are intentionally nonfunctional.

Appendix B. Retrieval Test Facts

Use these synthetic facts to test retrieval accuracy, metadata filters, exact-match queries, and answer citation behavior. Values below are deliberately specific.

Policy ID	Retrieval fact
LEAVE-130	Annual leave: 20 working days per calendar year for eligible full-time employees.
LEAVE-131	Paid sick time: 8 days per calendar year.
LEAVE-134	Carryover: up to 5 annual-leave days, expiring March 31.
PAY-140	Payroll: biweekly, every other Friday.
BEN-151	Learning budget: up to 1,200 currency units per year; pre-approval required.
WORK-120	Hybrid schedule: 3 remote days and 2 office days per week by default.
OPS-111	Flexible-hours request response target: 5 business days.
SEC-182	Report suspected phishing to security@example.invalid; do not click suspicious links.
IT-191	Do not paste Restricted information or confidential personnel records into public AI services.
EXP-221	Submit expenses within 15 calendar days after the trip or purchase.
SAFE-174	Sample report acknowledgment target: 2 business days.

Suggested RAG evaluation questions

- How many annual-leave days can be carried over, and when do they expire?
- What is the learning budget and what approval is needed?
- What should an employee do if a work laptop is lost?
- Which contact handles suspected phishing?
- How many business days are allowed for a flexible-hours response?
- Can restricted employee records be entered into a public AI tool?
- What information should be included in an expense claim?
- What is the sample process for responding to a workplace concern?